Problems, clients and decisions

What does it mean to solve a public problem systematically, and who are we solving it for?



Today

By the end of today, you will have

Sorted statements about your candidate cases into problems, symptoms, causes and solutions, and named a provisional decision-making role for each.

- Explain how the Lab works: one case, one shared method, four gates.
- Distinguish a problem from a symptom, a cause and a solution.
- Name a decision-making role and the decision it faces.
- Explain why public problems are harder to define than a firm's.

Competencies: A1 · A3 · A4

Session plan

10 min	**Opening problem**
15 min	**How the Lab works**
20 min	**Problem, symptom, cause, solution**
35 min	**Activity: ten-minute challenge**
25 min	**Own case: candidate sort**
15 min	**Debrief and exit task**

Opening problem

- **A district runs more than twenty welfare schemes, yet eligible families in its remote blocks say they receive nothing. What, exactly, is the problem?**

Take two minutes alone. Write one sentence that states the problem. Do not propose a solution and do not explain why it happens.

How the Lab works

1 One case, carried for twenty days

You choose an Indian public problem and take it from a vague concern to a defended recommendation. Every worksheet builds part of your final report.

2 One method, shared by the cohort

Everyone learns the same tools. Your pod of four works on four different cases, so you see each tool used four ways.

3 Four gates

On Days 5, 10, 15 and 19 you submit your work for detailed feedback. Revising in response to feedback is where most of the learning happens.

4 A decision, not an essay

The programme ends with a recommendation to a named decision-maker, defended in front of a panel.

The method: seven steps to a diagnosis, then a choice

1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Define	**Disaggregate**	**Prioritise**	**Plan the work**	**Analyse**	**Synthesise**	**Communicate**
What decision, for whom? Week 1	Break the problem into questions. Week 1	Keep the branches that matter. Week 2	Which analysis, which source? Week 2	Test against published evidence. Week 3	So what? Week 3	What should be done? Week 4

Week 4 adds Bardach's eightfold path: alternatives, criteria, outcomes, trade-offs, decision and story.

Four things that get confused with the problem

P

Problem

A gap between the current and the desired condition, for a defined group, that someone has the authority to close. Madhyapur: most households do not hand over segregated waste.

S

Symptom

An observable sign of the problem, often felt by a different group. Madhyapur: overflowing mixed-waste points on main roads.

C

Cause

A possible reason the gap exists. Until it is tested, it is only a hypothesis. Madhyapur: collection vehicles have no separate compartments.

A

Solution

An action someone could take. It belongs at the end of the analysis, not the start. Madhyapur: fine households that do not segregate.

Madhyapur is the course's running case: a stylised city. Its details are for teaching, not a description of any real city.

Sort practice: six statements about Madhyapur

Statement	Category	Why
Most households hand over mixed waste	Problem	It states the gap between required and actual behaviour for a defined group
The landfill site at the edge of the city is close to full	Symptom	A visible consequence of mixed waste reaching landfill, not the gap itself
Collection crews tip separated bags into one compartment	Cause (candidate)	It may explain why households stop separating; it needs evidence
Give every household two bins	Solution	An action has slipped into the description
Residents near transfer points complain about smell	Symptom	A sign, felt by a particular group
The collection contractor is paid by the tonne	Cause (candidate)	It may reward collecting mixed waste; a hypothesis to test

Every problem is defined for a decision-maker

- **A problem statement is only useful if someone can act on it. Name the role, and the decision that role faces.**

Madhyapur: the Municipal Commissioner must decide, before the next budget, which of three compliance strategies to fund. That decision tells us what to analyse and what we can leave out.

A thinker for your case

Rittel and Webber

"Dilemmas in a General Theory of Planning", Policy Sciences, 1973

They argued that most public problems are wicked: they have no definitive formulation and no stopping rule, and every attempt to solve one changes it.

The question it puts to your case

Whose definition of the problem are you adopting, and what would count as solved?

Answer it in one sentence in your workbook today.

Why public problems are harder to define than a firm's

A firm

- One main objective, usually profit
- One decision-maker with a budget
- Success measured in one unit
- Customers can walk away

A public problem

- Several legitimate objectives that conflict
- Authority divided between Union, state and local bodies
- Success may be what people can do, not one number
- Citizens often cannot exit, and some have no voice

Consulting tools still work, provided the analyst keeps these differences in view.

Activity: The ten-minute problem challenge

Experience how quickly a group jumps to solutions, then rebuild the problem properly.

Scenario

A district runs more than twenty central and state welfare schemes. At a district grievance meeting, families from remote blocks say they receive nothing, although many appear eligible. The District Collector turns to your team: what is the problem, and what do we need to find out first? You have ten minutes.

What to do

1. In ten minutes, write the problem in one sentence and list what you need to find out.
2. Swap with another pod. Mark every phrase as problem, symptom, cause or solution.
3. Rewrite your own statement so it contains no cause and no solution.
4. Name the role that would act on it and the decision that role faces.
5. Be ready to read your before and after statements aloud.

Time 35 minutes

Groups Pods of four

Output Before and after statements with a named decision-maker

Your case: Worksheet 1.1

Sorting your candidate cases

1. List three candidate problems you might work on, one line each.
2. For each, write five statements you believe to be true about it.
3. Sort every statement into problem, symptom, cause or solution.
4. Rewrite each candidate as a problem statement with no cause or solution in it.
5. Name a role that could act on each, and the decision it faces.

Hand in

Worksheet 1.1 with three sorted candidates and a provisional choice, by the start of Day 2.

Quality check

No problem statement contains a cause or a solution.

Tag every claim in your Analyst's Ledger: fact, inference, assumption or hypothesis.

What to take away

1. Most first drafts of a problem statement contain a cause or a solution. Finding them is the first skill.
2. A problem is a gap, for a defined group, that someone has the authority to close.
3. Name the decision-maker and the decision early: they tell you what to analyse.
4. Public problems are contested. Say whose definition you are adopting.

Exit task Write your best candidate problem in one sentence, with no cause and no solution in it.

Before the next session

Independent work

Finish Worksheet 1.1. For the candidate you are most likely to choose, open two public data sources and note what each covers, at what level (state, district or city) and for which year. Bring both to Day 2. About 45 minutes.

Read

Rittel and Webber, "Dilemmas in a General Theory of Planning" (1973). Read the ten properties of wicked problems.

Next

Day 2: Defining the problem

Tomorrow we turn your best candidate into a bounded, decision-focused problem statement and submit the Case Approval Form.